

CPQ Decision 2026

**REVENUE CLOUD? THIRD-PARTY CPQ?
OR NATIVE CPQ LIGHT?**

Comparison of Salesforce Revenue Cloud, Traditional CPQ Tools, and Native CPQ Light: A Practical Decision Guide for B2B Sales Organisations

Table of Contents

1.WHY CPQ IS A STRATEGIC PRIORITY IN 2026..... 4

2. THE THREE CPQ OPTIONS AT A GLANCE 6

2.1 Salesforce Revenue Cloud.....7

2.2 Traditional Third-Party CPQ Systems.....8

2.3 CPQ Light – Native Salesforce Solutions (Example: appero quote)9

3. EVALUATION MODEL: COMPLEXITY, COST, AND TIME-TO-VALUE.....10

4. COMPARISON MATRIX: REVENUE CLOUD VS. THIRD-PARTY VS. NATIVE CPQ LIGHT12

4.1 Summary Overview13

4.2 Evaluation Criteria Analysis14

4.2.1 Complexity14

4.2.2 Cost15

4.2.3 Time-to-Value16

Table of Contents

5. SCENARIO-BASED DECISION GUIDE	17
5.1 Scenario A – Enterprise & Global, Complex Monetisation	18
5.2 Scenario B – Mid-Market Organisations with Traditional B2B Offerings.....	19
5.3 Scenario C – Specialised Industry-Specific Requirements.	20
6. SIX STEPS TO YOUR 2026 CPQ DECISION.....	21
7. DECISION CHECKLIST: WHICH OPTION IS RIGHT FOR YOU?.....	23
8. CONCLUSION	25



WHY CPQ IS A STRATEGIC PRIORITY IN 2026

WHY CPQ IS A STRATEGIC PRIORITY IN 2026

While many organisations use Salesforce Sales Cloud as their central CRM, they often still rely on Word templates, Excel spreadsheets, and manual approvals to create quotes. This approach creates bottlenecks, leads to costly errors, and makes it difficult to manage pricing and discount rules centrally. As product portfolios grow, international teams scale, or recurring subscription models are introduced, a Configure-Price-Quote (CPQ) system becomes the essential lever to:



Ensure Consistent Pricing and Discount Rules



Speed up the entire quoting process



Gain clearer insights into pipeline and revenue management



Establish a reliable data foundation for forecasting and reporting

Salesforce customers typically face three strategic options:

Salesforce Revenue Cloud
(including Salesforce CPQ)

Traditional Third-Party CPQ
Systems Integrated with
Salesforce

CPQ Light: Lean, Native CPQ
Extensions for Sales Cloud
such as appero quote

This whitepaper outlines the three options and evaluates them based on the criteria of **complexity**, **cost**, and **time-to-value**—providing an objective decision-making framework for 2026.

Would you like to learn more?
Contact us!



+47 9579 0577



geir@redorangetechnologies.com

The Three CPQ Options at a Glance



2

The Three CPQ Options at a Glance

2.1 SALESFORCE REVENUE CLOUD

Salesforce Revenue Cloud is a product suite covering the entire quote-to-cash process: from configuration and pricing to billing and subscription management, as well as revenue recognition and partner management.

Strengths

Very broad functional scope: complex configuration, subscription models, contract and pricing logic, billing, and revenue recognition

Deeply and technically mature integration into the Salesforce platform

Extensive partner and implementation ecosystem, with numerous enterprise references

Challenges

Higher complexity across the data model, rule architecture, and system administration

Typically implemented as a multi-month transformation initiative

Licensing and implementation costs in the premium segment, including higher per-user list prices for CPQ and Revenue Cloud editions compared to light alternatives

Typical Use Cases

Enterprise Environment

Complex, International Sales Organisations

Advanced subscription and usage-based models, with requirements for billing and revenue recognition

The Three CPQ Options at a Glance

2.2 TRADITIONAL THIRD-PARTY CPQ SYSTEMS

By “traditional CPQ tools,” we refer to solutions that are typically integrated to Salesforce via managed packages or integration connectors, such as DealHub, Conga CPQ, PROS Smart CPQ, CloudSense, Tacton, and others.

Strengths (Aggregated View)

Highly powerful configuration and pricing engines; in some cases specialised for manufacturing, telco/ media, or subscription-based

Advanced features such as guided selling, deal rooms, visual configurators, or pricing optimisation

Well suited for organisations not relying exclusively on Salesforce (multi-CRM or multi-ERP environments)

Challenges

Integration typically relies on proprietary data models, synchronisation jobs, or middleware

Higher training requirements and complex administration

Implementation and licensing costs in the mid- to upper range, depending on functionality and industry

Typical Use Cases

Industries with highly complex product structures (e.g., manufacturing with high product variability, telco, high-tech)

Organisations with heterogeneous system landscapes or a strong focus on specialised capabilities (e.g., pricing optimisation, 3D configuration)

The Three CPQ Options at a Glance

2.3 CPQ LIGHT – NATIVE SALESFORCE SOLUTIONS

CPQ light solutions focus on the core: Pricing and Quote generation—delivering robust calculations without the full complexity of Enterprise CPQ

Strengths (appero quote)

Powerful rule-based pricing calculation (tiered pricing, multi-level discounts, customer-specific pricing)

Low implementation effort: often live within a few weeks; list prices in the lower range (e.g., ~€33 per user/month) compared to enterprise CPQ

Lightning editor for quote documents—brand-compliant, with images, text blocks, and placeholders pulled directly from Salesforce

Fully native integration with no middleware; data remains within the Salesforce Org and therefore falls under Salesforce's security standards. Custom extensions within the quoting process can be implemented using native Salesforce capabilities, such as Flows.n.

Product configuration based on product attributes with or without calculations, including simple bundles and accessory products

Particularly well suited for mid-sized companies. Scales efficiently to moderate levels of complexity

Deliberate Scope Limitation

No full-scale "Configure" capabilities with highly dynamic bundles and complex dependency rules

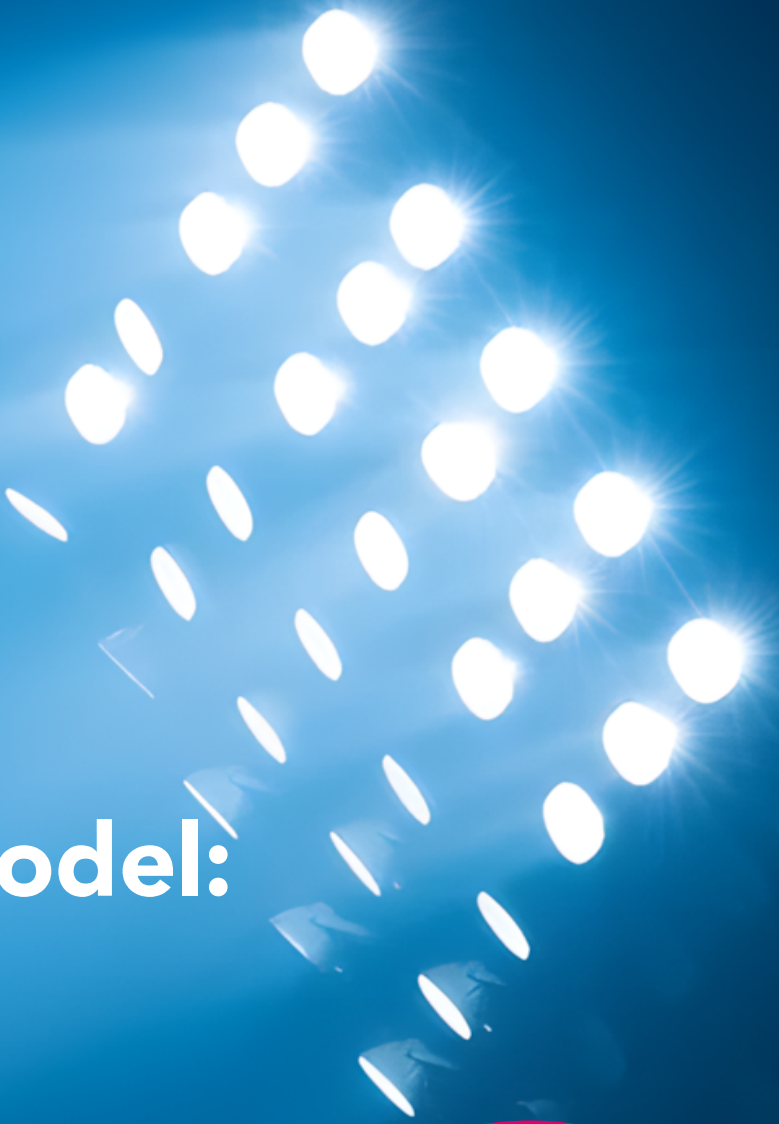
No built-in billing or revenue recognition—these capabilities can be complemented through specialised partner solutions (e.g., JustOn)

Typical Use Cases

Mid-sized B2B companies with standardised, but not highly complex quoting processes

Traditional project, service, or product quotes that need to be created cleanly, quickly, and in a brand-compliant manner

Teams that are still using Word and Excel today and are looking for visible improvements in the short term



Evaluation Model: Complexity, Cost, and Time-to-Value

3

Evaluation Model: Complexity, Cost, and Time-to-Value

A pragmatic CPQ decision boils down to three criteria:

1

COMPLEXITY

- How complex are implementation, configuration, and day-to-day administration?
- How easy is it to add new products, pricing rules, or users?

2

COST

- Licensing costs (list prices per user/module, if applicable platform add-ons)
- Implementation (implementation project, potentially involving external consulting)

3

TIME-TO-VALUE

- How quickly is tangible value realised?
- How quickly can use cases be rolled out iteratively?

We evaluate each option on a 1-to-5 scale:

1

3

5

very negative

very high complexity
very expensive
long time to value

average

very positive

low complexity
low cost
very fast time-to-value

The ratings are intentionally kept generic and are based on a combination of functional, integration, and cost comparisons of the solutions mentioned within the Salesforce ecosystem.



Comparison Matrix: Revenue Cloud vs. Third- Party CPQ vs. CPQ Light

4

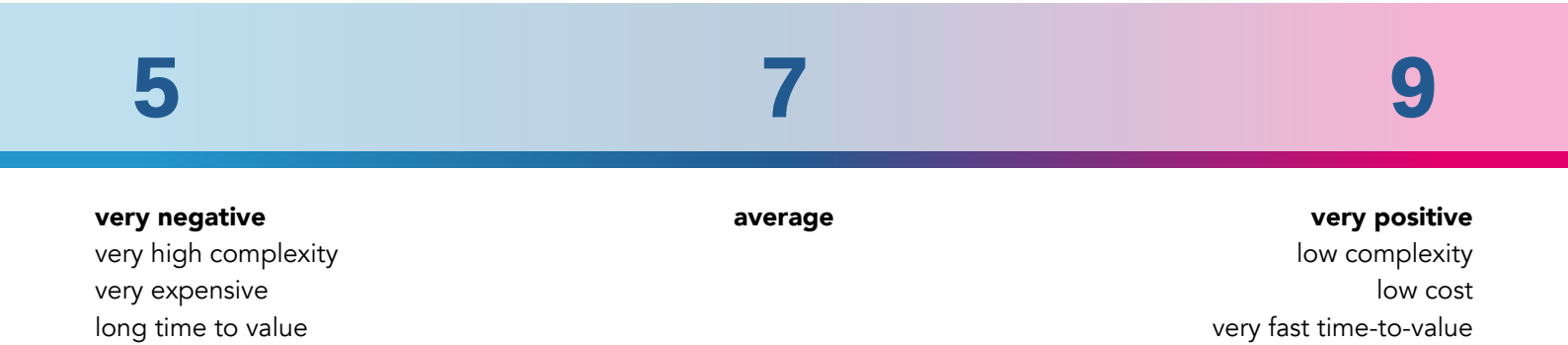
Comparison Matrix

Revenue Cloud vs. Third-Party CPQ vs. CPQ Light

4.1 SUMMARY OVERVIEW TABLE

	Salesforce Revenue Cloud	Third-Party CPQ	Native CPQ Light
Complexity	2 high	3 average to high	4 focused
Cost	2 high	3 average	5 low
Time-to-value	3 average	3 average	5 very fast

We evaluate each option on a 1-to-5 scale:



Comparison Matrix Revenue Cloud vs. Third-Party CPQ vs. CPQ Light

4.2 COMMENTARY ON THE CRITERIA

	Salesforce Revenue Cloud	Third-Party CPQ	appero quote – CPQ Light
Complexity	2 high	3 average to high	4 focused and manageable
Cost	2 high	3 average	5 low
Time-to-value	3 average	3 average	5 very fast

Salesforce Revenue Cloud 2 5

- Covers CPQ, billing, subscriptions, and revenue—resulting in inherently complex data models, rule frameworks, and workflows.
- Implementation typically requires a dedicated project team and experienced implementation partners.

Third-Party CPQ 3 5

- Offers powerful engines (guided selling, variant logic, 3D configurators).
- Simultaneously adds complexity via integration layers, proprietary data models, and separate administration interfaces.

appero quote – CPQ Light 4 5

- Deliberately focuses on pricing and quote generation, i.e., quote calculation and document generation.
- Native integration, a Lightning Editor, and the use of Salesforce's permission logic result in significantly lower day-to-day complexity.

Comparison Matrix: Revenue Cloud vs. Third-Party CPQ vs. CPQ Light

4.2 COMMENTARY ON THE CRITERIA

	Salesforce Revenue Cloud	Third-Party CPQ	appero quote – CPQ Light
Complexity	2 high	3 average to high	4 focused and manageable
Cost	2 high	3 average	5 low
Time-to-Value	3 average	3 average	5 very fast

Salesforce Revenue Cloud (2/5)

- Higher list prices for CPQ and Revenue Cloud editions; additional costs apply for billing and other modules.
- Implementation is resource-intensive and typically involves external partners.

Third-Party CPQ (3/5)

- Licensing price levels and project costs typically fall in the mid- to higher range, depending on industry segment
- In return, they often offer a very strong feature set within their respective niche.

appero quote – CPQ Light (5/5)

- Significantly lower licensing price level (example: appero quote with a list price of around €33 per user/month).
- Rollout can start small and be expanded iteratively—resulting in lower initial project costs.

Comparison Matrix

Revenue Cloud vs. Third-Party CPQ vs. CPQ Light

4.2 COMMENTARY ON THE CRITERIA

	Salesforce Revenue Cloud	Third-Party CPQ	appero quote – CPQ Light
Complexity	2 high	3 average to high	4 focused and manageable
Cost	2 high	3 average	5 low
Time-to-value	3 average	3 average	5 very fast

Salesforce Revenue Cloud 3 5

- Delivers long-term value—particularly with an end-to-end quote-to-cash process.
- Due to the breadth of functionality and integration effort, it typically takes several months before business teams see tangible improvements.

Third-Party CPQ 3 5

- Time-to-value depends heavily on the vendor and setup; typically in the range of several months.
- Specialised solutions (particularly in telco and manufacturing) often require detailed modeling projects.

appero quote – CPQ Light 5 5

- Focused scope, native integration, and ease of use allow for rollout in weeks instead of months.

Scenario-Based Decision Guide



5

Scenario-Based Decision Guide

5.1 SCENARIO A ENTERPRISE & GLOBAL, COMPLEX MONETISATION

Key Characteristics

Multiple business units/
countries, complex approval
processes

Subscriptions, usage-based
pricing, multi-level discount
hierarchies

Requirements for automated
billing, revenue recognition,
compliance, and audit

Recommended Direction

Salesforce Revenue Cloud (including Salesforce CPQ) or a
comparable enterprise CPQ with billing and revenue capabilities

Benefits: end-to-end quote-to-cash process, strong governance, global scalability

Would you like to learn more?
Contact us!



+47 9579 0577



geir@redorangetechnologies.com

Scenario-Based Decision Guide

5.2 SCENARIO B MID-MARKET ORGANISATIONS

Key Characteristics

Salesforce Sales Cloud in use (or planned rollout)

Quoting processes today are largely document-driven (Word/Excel)

Products, services, and fixed-fee offerings with sophisticated pricing but moderate complexity

Focus: efficiency gains, standardisation, and brand-compliant documents

Recommended Direction

appero quote – CPO Light as a native extension; integration of e-signature and, if required, simple subscription management via partner solutions.

Would you like to learn more?
Contact us!



+47 9579 0577



geir@redorangetechnologies.com

Scenario-Based Decision Guide

5.3 SCENARIO C SPECIALISED REQUIREMENTS

Key Characteristics

Highly complex product variants, technical dependencies, and configurators

Highly regulated industries (telco, utilities, manufacturing)

Existing system landscape partly outside Salesforce

Recommended Direction

Traditional third-party CPQ systems with an industry focus (e.g., manufacturing CPQ, telco/media CPQ), integrated with Salesforce.

Revenue Cloud is a compelling option if the goal is a seamless, end-to-end Salesforce stack.

Would you like to learn more?
Contact us!



+47 9579 0577



geir@redorangetechnologies.com

The CPQ Decision 2026 in Six Steps

6

The CPQ Decision 2026 in Six Steps



1. Collect Use Cases

- What types of quotes exist? What errors occur today? Which KPIs should be improved?

2. Honestly Assess Complexity

- Do you truly need dynamic bundles, multi-tier subscriptions, and complex billing logic—or simply need well-structured quotes, clear pricing, and approvals?

3. Analyse the Landscape

- Is Salesforce the central hub?
- How important is “100% native” vs. a “best-of-breed combination”?

4. Pre-score Your Options

- Map Revenue Cloud, 1–2 third-party systems, and at least one CPQ light option along the three core criteria.
- Use the evaluation matrix from Chapter 4.

5. Define the Business Case

- How much manual effort, error-related costs, and uplift in win rate can you realistically reduce or achieve?
- Which option delivers visible value within 3–6 months—and which supports the long-term transformation story?

6. Pilot & Rollout

- Start with a focused pilot area (e.g., one business unit or a specific product line).
- Collect KPI-based insights (cycle times, quote quality, win rate) and scale afterwards.



Decision Checklist: Which Option Is Right for You?



Decision Checklist: Which Option Is Right for You?

Answer the following questions with **Yes** / **No**. The overall tendency indicates which direction you should take:



Our quotes primarily consist of **standard products without highly complex logic**.



We need measurable impact on data quality within **< 6 months**.



Salesforce is our **primary system**—ideally without a bloated integration zoo.



Budget and resources for a multi-year transformation program are **limited**.



We do **not** require integrated billing or complex revenue recognition logic.



Our admins should handle the configuration **themselves**



We want to quickly convert our **existing quote templates** into brand-compliant CPQ documents.



Our product and pricing logic is not trivial, but **manageable** (tiered pricing, discounts, customer groups).

If **five or more statements apply**, there is a very strong case for choosing a Native **CPQ light** solution such as appero quote.

If **fewer than three statements apply**, consider Revenue Cloud or a **traditional enterprise CPQ solution**.

If you're in **between**, compare one or two third-party systems with a CPQ Light option and consider starting with Light before scaling to enterprise.

Conclusion





Conclusion

The CPQ decision in 2026 is less about “feature lists” and more about **fit**

Revenue Cloud is worthwhile if you have an end-to-end Salesforce quote-to-cash platform, complex monetisation models, and a global enterprise setup.

Traditional third-party CPQ systems are ideal when industry-specific deep requirements or a heterogeneous system landscape are the focus.

appero quote – CPQ Light offers the best balance of complexity, cost, and time-to-value for the mid-market—with clear strengths in usability, native integration, and rapid implementation.

This provides you with a compact yet well-founded framework to define your CPQ strategy for 2026 and find the right balance for your organisation between functionality and pragmatism.

Would you like to learn more?
Contact us!



+47 9579 0577



geir@redorangetechnologies.com